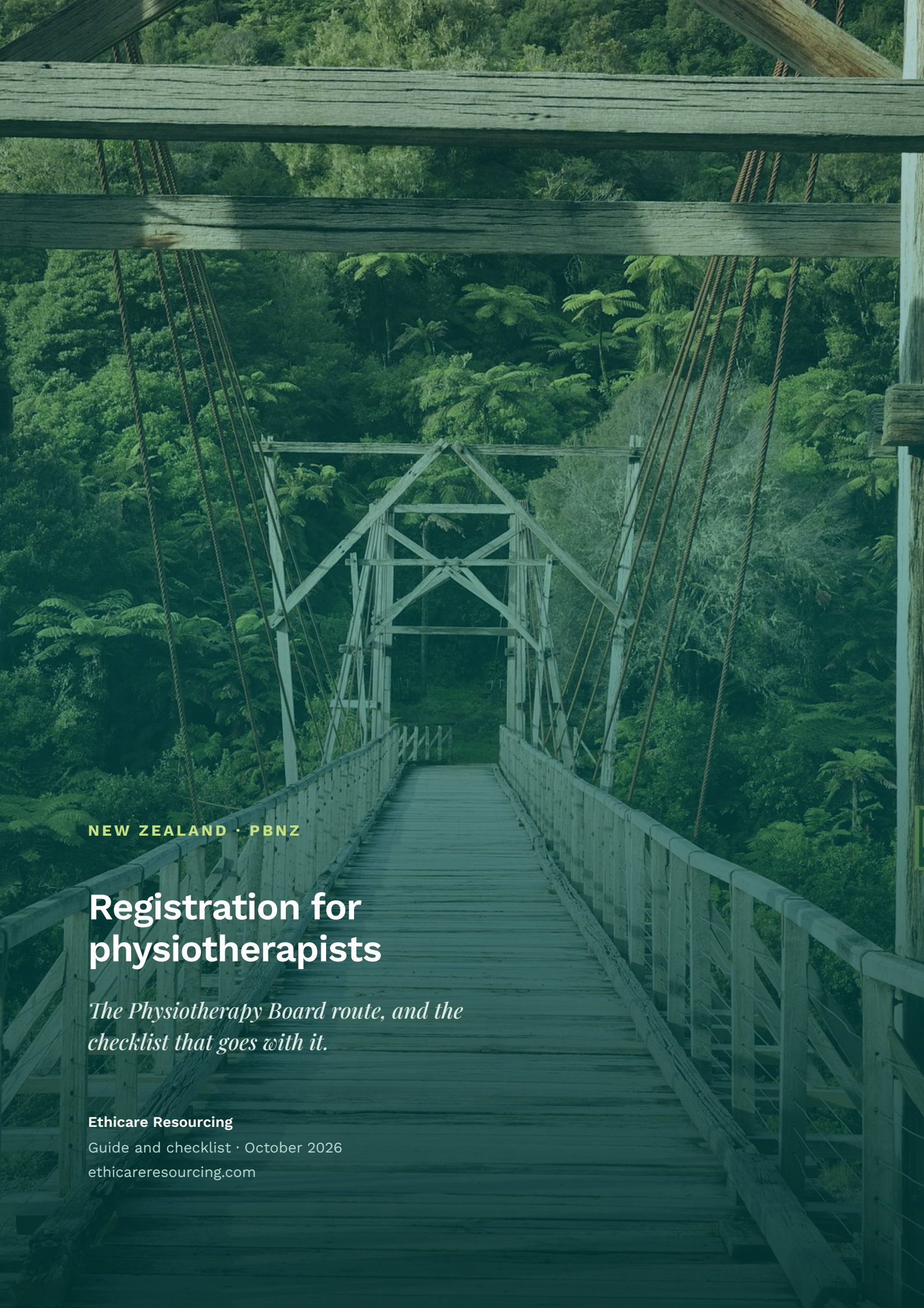




NEW ZEALAND • PBNZ

Registration for physiotherapists

*The Physiotherapy Board route, and the
checklist that goes with it.*

Ethicare Resourcing

Guide and checklist • October 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Registering with the Physiotherapy Board

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Registering with the Physiotherapy Board

For internationally qualified physiotherapists: which of the three pathways is yours, what the Practice Thresholds ask of you, the two cultural competency courses you can start today – and the checklist built into the page so nothing you tick goes out of date.



Regulator

Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand — Te Poari Tiaki Tinana o Aotearoa — under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act

Source

The Board's published requirements at physioboard.org.nz. Where this page and the Board differ, the Board is right.

Status

Checked 3 October 2026 against physioboard.org.nz — the Express, General, Fast Track and TTMR pathway pages, the English proficiency evidence page and the fees schedule. Fees are not printed here because the Board revises them.

Fees & timings

Deliberately not printed. The Board publishes both and changes them; check its current schedule before you budget.

AT A GLANCE

Registration comes first

An employer generally wants to see you are registered, or clearly registrable, before progressing your application. Plan everything else on top of it.

Three pathways – get yours right first

Express (UK, Ireland, Canada, South Africa), Trans-Tasman (Ahpra-registered in Australia) or General (everyone else). The wrong one is the most common avoidable delay.

Assessed against the Practice Thresholds

A shared Australia–New Zealand set of competencies. Read them before you apply; they are the yardstick for everything you submit.

Two cultural competency courses

Online, within your control, required. The one part of the application you can finish today.

What's inside

Read it once to understand the shape of the journey, then come back to each section as you reach it. The checklist at the end remembers what you have ticked, on this device.

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SECTION 01

Understanding the Board

The Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand registers and oversees physiotherapists under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act. Its purpose is to protect the public by making sure everyone practising as a physiotherapist is qualified, competent and fit to do so. The title and practice of physiotherapy are legally protected: you cannot practise, or call yourself a physiotherapist, without registration and a current Annual Practising Certificate.

The Practice Thresholds

What sets physiotherapy apart is what you are assessed against. Every application is measured against the *Physiotherapy Practice Thresholds in Australia and Aotearoa New Zealand* — a shared set of competencies describing what a physiotherapist must be able to do, safely and effectively, to register and practise. Get to know them early; Section 04 covers them in detail.

Registration, the APC and your HPI number

Registration confirms you have met the standard and does not expire. The Annual Practising Certificate (APC) is what permits you to work, renewed each year; the physiotherapy APC year runs to 31 March and is managed through the Board's MyPBNZ portal. Once registered you are added to the public Register of Physiotherapists and the Ministry of Health issues your Health Practitioner Index (HPI) number. Registration is an ongoing commitment: competence, ethical practice and annual CPD the Board can audit.

Qualification → Registration — General Scope → Annual Practising Certificate → Practise in New Zealand

SECTION 02

Scopes of practice

Three scopes exist. For anyone applying from overseas, one matters to begin with: every physiotherapist must first be registered in the General Scope.

Your application is for this

General Scope

Where every physiotherapist begins. The full breadth of autonomous practice — assessment, diagnosis and treatment — across musculoskeletal, neurological, cardiorespiratory and other areas.

Later

Advanced Practice Physiotherapist

For advanced skills in areas such as musculoskeletal, neurology or cardiorespiratory practice. Not an entry point: it needs unrestricted General Scope registration, a current APC, a relevant postgraduate qualification and experience including time practising in New Zealand.

Later

Specialist Scope

The most advanced scope, for physiotherapists recognised as specialists in their field. Built on General Scope registration and New Zealand practice — something to progress toward, not a route in.

What this means for you.

Apply for the General Scope. The other two are progression options once you are registered, hold an APC and have built experience here. Nothing to think about yet — but reassuring that the career pathway exists.

SECTION 03

Which registration pathway is yours

The single most important thing to get right at the start. PBNZ has four distinct pathways, and which one you use depends entirely on where you trained and where you are registered.

Pathway 1

International Express Pathway

Who: physiotherapists connected to the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa – either unrestricted registration there (HCPC, CORU, HPCSA or a Canadian physiotherapy regulator) or a physiotherapy qualification from one of them recognised as pre-registration by that regulator.

Why it exists: the Board treats those four jurisdictions as closely aligned with New Zealand, so the Express Pathway removes duplication of what you have already proven.

Pathway 2

Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition

Who: physiotherapists holding either full or limited registration with Ahpra in Australia.

Why it exists: under the Trans-Tasman arrangement, registration in one country is recognised in the other. You apply under TTMR, not as an overseas-trained applicant.

Worth knowing: limited registration carries supervision conditions, and those conditions apply in New Zealand too. It is the only supervision requirement on any of the overseas pathways.

Pathway 3

International General: Fast Track

Who: Fiji National University qualifications from 2013 onwards, and Hong Kong SAR physiotherapy degrees granted since 2015.

Why it exists: you follow the General application process, but the Board has pre-identified which competencies need supplementary evidence – so it is a shorter road than General from a standing start.

Pathway 4

International General Pathway

Who: everyone else – no recognised qualification or unrestricted registration in the UK, Ireland, Canada, South Africa or Australia.

Why it exists: it assesses your qualification and competence directly against the Practice Thresholds, with a structured way to demonstrate any competency your curriculum does not already evidence (Section 04).

1

Registered with Ahpra in Australia?

Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition.

2

Qualified or registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa?

International Express Pathway.

3

Qualified at Fiji National University from 2013, or in Hong Kong SAR since 2015?

International General: Fast Track. You use the General application process, but the Board has already identified which competencies need supplementary evidence.

4

Anywhere else?

International General Pathway.

The wrong pathway costs time.

Applying under General when you qualify for Express, or the reverse, is one of the most common avoidable delays. If you are unsure where you fall, [check before you start](#).

SECTION 04

The Practice Thresholds and how assessment works

The Practice Thresholds describe the threshold competence required for initial registration and continuing practice – what you must be able to do, safely and effectively, across assessment, clinical reasoning, intervention, communication, professional behaviour and safety. They are shared across Australia and New Zealand, which is why Australian-registered physiotherapists move so smoothly between the two systems.

On the General Pathway, assessment runs through five phases. Knowing them in advance removes most of the anxiety, because you can see exactly where you are at any point.

1

Document check

The Board reviews your application for completeness. If anything is missing or eligibility is in question, you are emailed before it proceeds.

2

Qualification assessment

An assessor reviews how well the curriculum of your primary physiotherapy degree aligns with each key competency. Two outcomes: every competency met, and the application goes straight forward; or gaps, and it moves to Phase 3. Neither is unusual – curricula differ between countries.

3

Request for supporting evidence — only if needed

You are told exactly which competencies to demonstrate and have three months to provide evidence. Competencies already shown do not need proving again.

4

Assessment of supporting evidence

If it meets the criteria you proceed; if not, you can submit more based on the assessor's feedback.

5

Registration

Applications that meet the requirement go to the Registrar for approval, and you receive email confirmation.

Demonstrating competencies, if you reach Phase 3

The Board's request sets out precisely which competencies need evidencing, and it publishes a *Guidance on Providing Supporting Evidence* document with templates – a Reflections template and a Validation of Work History form. Read them; they help you choose high-quality evidence. Give specific examples and detail from your training or work, clearly named and well organised.

Read the Thresholds before you apply.

Map your experience to each competency. If you can already see where your curriculum might be light, start gathering specific, detailed examples now – the evidence phase, if it comes, is then far quicker.

SECTION 05

Eligibility requirements

Far easier to satisfy once you understand why each one exists – so that is how they are explained here.

A recognised physiotherapy qualification

Why: your qualification is the foundation of safe practice. The Board needs confidence your training covered the Practice Thresholds – which is why course content can matter as much as the certificate, particularly on the General Pathway.

Registration and good standing

Why: if you are, or have been, registered as a physiotherapist anywhere, the Board needs to know you are in good standing with no unresolved concerns. This underpins the Express and TTMR pathways and supports the General Pathway too.

Recency of practice

Why: skills fade when unused. If you have had a significant break, flag it early – depending on the gap, a Return to Practice process may apply.

English language

Why: patient safety. Taking histories, explaining treatment, communicating precisely with patients and colleagues. Section 08.

Fitness for registration

Why: your physical and mental fitness to practise safely, and your professional conduct history. Full, honest disclosure – even of matters you think minor or resolved – is always right. Non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than the underlying matter usually is.

Cultural competency

Why: practising safely in New Zealand means understanding its cultural context, including Te Tiriti o Waitangi and Māori health. PBNZ requires evidence of cultural competency training – specific enough to have its own section, 07.

Read every requirement as a question.

The Board is asking whether you are safe to practise. Frame each document as the answer and your application becomes far more persuasive.

SECTION 06

Preparing your application

A strong application is rarely about doing anything clever. It is clean, complete, correctly certified documents, presented well.

The Board is forming a picture of you as a professional, and a folder of crooked, half-legible photocopies undermines it even when every document is genuine. Clean colour scans, pages straight and square, nothing cut off, consistent file names, certification done properly the first time.

Identity

Why

Confirms who you are; underpins your visa and right to work.

Accepted

A passport or birth certificate, plus a name-change document (marriage certificate, deed poll) if your name differs across documents.

Tip

Scan flat, in colour, with all edges visible.

Your qualification documents

Why

Your primary physiotherapy qualification is the basis of registration; on the General Pathway these are what the curriculum assessment works from.

Required

General Pathway: your degree, academic transcript, curriculum and a clinical hours profile – all four.

Express Pathway: the degree or academic transcript for your primary physiotherapy qualification, **and** certificates of good standing from every regulatory authority you have been registered with. Both are required – registration evidence does not stand in for the qualification document.

Mistake

Sending only the degree and transcript. The curriculum and clinical hours profile are required and frequently forgotten.

Certificates of Good Standing

Why

Confirm good standing with every physiotherapy regulator you have registered with.

Timing

Each must be less than three months old on the date you submit. Requesting too early is a frequent, avoidable reason to start again.

Tip

Line them up to be fresh at submission, not months before.

Police or criminal history certificates

Why

The Board must protect patients, so it checks your background.

Required

From any country you have lived in for more than twelve months in the last ten years since age eighteen – and, like Good Standing, each less than three months old at submission.

Tip

They can take time to obtain, so balance starting early against the three-month rule.

CV — on the Board's template

Why

Evidences your experience and recency of practice.

Mistake

Submitting your own CV format. The Board requires its own downloadable template and will send yours back.

Tip

Complete it fully, accounting for every period including gaps. [Build your CV](#) helps you assemble the content before you transfer it.

Certification and translations

Why

Certification confirms a true copy of the original.

The rule

Each required document is either certified, or sent directly to the Board by the issuing authority.

Translations of any non-English document must also be provided.

Tip

Confirm who may certify and the wording before you spend money. Getting it wrong means doing it twice.

SECTION 07

Cultural competency requirements

A requirement that surprises many international applicants – and the one you can begin today, before you have gathered a single other document.

PBNZ requires evidence of cultural competency training as part of registration, typically certificates from two recognised courses. They cover cultural safety, Te Tiriti o Waitangi and its place in healthcare, and working effectively with Māori and New Zealand's diverse communities. Safe physiotherapy here is not only clinical skill; Te Tiriti is foundational to the health system and cultural safety is treated as a core part of competent practice, not an optional extra.

Mauri Ora Associates

Foundations in Cultural Competency

Counts as one of your two.

Mauri Ora Associates

Foundations Course on Healthcare and the Treaty of Waitangi

Counts as one of your two.

Ministry of Health, via Ko Awatea LEARN

Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning, Modules One and Two

You will need to request an account and provide your international registration number. Both modules together count as **one** course.

An easy mistake.

Ngā Paerewa Modules One and Two combined count as one of the two courses you need. Completing Ngā Paerewa alone is not enough: pair it with a Mauri Ora course, or complete both Mauri Ora courses. Plan for two distinct courses.

Start these first.

They are online and entirely within your control, so they are the easiest thing to finish ahead of time – and a genuine introduction to the healthcare culture you are joining, not just a box to tick.

— SECTION 08

English language requirements

This exists for one reason: patient safety. The Board needs objective assurance of your ability.

Without a test

Three routes, and one of them is narrower than people assume

English as your first language, with documentation. A **pre-registration physiotherapy qualification from the United Kingdom, Ireland, Canada or South Africa** – note that this is about where the qualification is from, not whether you were taught in English. Or other evidence of an English-speaking background acceptable to the Registrar.

Four accepted tests

IELTS Academic, OET, PTE Academic or TOEFL iBT

Any of the four. Each has minimums in every component, and a strong overall score does not rescue a weak one – prepare evenly. The Board publishes the current figures; check them before you book.

Two sittings

Scores can be combined

Across two sittings within six months, subject to floors in each component that differ by test. If you narrowly miss one component, that is usually cheaper than re-sitting the whole thing.

Results expire.

Typically around two years from the test date. Sitting the test early and then taking many months to assemble the rest is a frequent reason for paying to sit it again. Time it to remain valid through to assessment. Sit a timed practice test first, find your weakest component, and book early.

— SECTION 09

Completing and submitting your application

1

Confirm your pathway

Express, TTMR or General – it determines what you submit. Section 03.

2

Complete your cultural competency courses

Ideally already done; they are within your control.

3

Create your application on MyPBNZ

Work through each section methodically and answer the fitness-for-registration questions accurately.

4

Upload your documents

Clean colour scans, certified where required, CV on the Board's template, clearly named.

5

Pay the fee and submit

Review everything one final time. Keep your payment confirmation.

6

Respond to any requests

On the General Pathway you may be asked for competency evidence – reply promptly and completely.

Understanding the fees

Depending on your pathway and circumstances the Board's charges include the registration or application fee and, once registered, your Annual Practising Certificate. On top sit third-party costs: police certificates, the cultural competency courses, any English test, and document certification or translation.

Amounts are deliberately not printed here. The Board publishes its prescribed fees on its website and revises them; confirm the current figures before you budget or pay. Where an Ethicare package applies to your placement, APC costs are reimbursed – ask us what your package includes before you rely on it.

SECTION 10

After you submit, and your APC

Submitting is a milestone, not the finish line.

1

Assessment

Against the Practice Thresholds. Generally quicker on the Express and TTMR pathways; on the General Pathway it may include the evidence phase in Section 04.

2

Requests for further information

Routine, not a red flag. A fast, complete response is the biggest thing within your control.

3

Registration decision

Applications that meet the requirements go to the Registrar. Once approved you are registered in the General Scope, added to the public Register, and issued your HPI number.

4

Apply for your APC

Registration alone does not let you work. Apply for your Annual Practising Certificate through MyPBNZ, confirming when you last practised. The APC year runs to 31 March.

5

Employment and relocation

With registration, or clear registrability, you are in a strong position to secure a role. This is where [planning the move](#) takes over from registration.

— WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Almost every avoidable delay traces back to one of these

The wrong pathway

General when you qualify for Express, or the reverse. Confirm your pathway first.

CV not on the Board template

Your own format is sent back.

Cultural competency left late

Within your control — leaving it to the end needlessly delays everything.

Expired Good Standing

Requested too early, over three months old at submission, reissued.

Poor-quality scans

Cropped, blurry or greyscale. If the assessor cannot read it, it does not count.

Incorrect certification

Wrong person or wrong wording — redone from scratch.

Thin competency evidence

On the General Pathway, vague evidence without specific examples mapped to each competency.

The fix for all of these

Confirm your pathway, prepare everything together, and have it read by someone else before you submit. Most of these are invisible to the person making them.

— SECTION 12

The questions we are asked most

Which pathway should I use?+

Can I apply for registration before finding a job?+

What scope will I be registered in?+

What are the Practice Thresholds?+

Do I really need the cultural competency courses?+

What if my curriculum does not cover every competency?+

Can I work while my application is being assessed?+

Can Ethicare review my application?+

SECTION 13

The whole journey on one page

From first decision to first day at work. Each stage links to the section that explains it.

Before you start

Confirm your pathway

Express, TTMR or General. [Section 03](#)

Before you start

Read the Practice Thresholds

Map your experience to each competency. [Section 04](#)

Start today

Cultural competency courses

Two distinct courses, online. [Section 07](#)

Preparing

Gather, certify and date your documents

Identity, qualification set, Good Standing and police certificates inside three months, CV on the template.

[Section 06](#)

Preparing

Evidence your English

The route that applies, valid through to assessment. [Section 08](#)

Applying

Submit via MyPBNZ

Fitness questions answered fee paid, final check. [Section 09](#)

Assessment

Against the Thresholds — evidence phase if needed

Respond within three months of any request. [Section 04 · 10](#)

Decision

Registration in the General Scope

Confirmed by the Registrar; HPI number issued.

Then

Annual Practising Certificate

Apply via MyPBNZ — you may now practise.

Then

Employment, visa and the move

Where registration hands over to [planning your move](#).

THE CHECKLIST

Thirty-nine items, in the order you will meet them

Tick as you go. Ticks are saved on this device only — nothing is sent to us — and the list is always the current version, which a downloaded copy never is.

0 of 39 ticked

[Clear all ticks](#)

01 Before you start

Get oriented before you spend money or gather documents.

☐ **Confirm which registration pathway is yours** Express (UK, Ireland, Canada, South Africa), TTMR (Ahpra-registered in Australia) or General (everyone else).

☐ **Read the Physiotherapy Practice Thresholds** The Australia–New Zealand competencies your whole application is assessed against.

☐ **Note that you will register in the General Scope** Advanced Practice and Specialist come later, after New Zealand experience.

☐ **Check recency-of-practice requirements** Flag any significant break early — a Return to Practice process may apply.

☐ **Note the current fees** From the Board's live schedule — figures change.

02 Cultural competency — start early

Two courses required, entirely within your control.

☐ **Complete a Mauri Ora course** Foundations in Cultural Competency, or Healthcare and the Treaty of Waitangi — counts as one of your two.

☐ **Complete a second, distinct course** The other Mauri Ora course, or Ngā Paerewa Modules One and Two.

☐ **Remember: Ngā Paerewa Modules One and Two count as one course** Pair it with a Mauri Ora course.

☐ **Save all completion certificates** You upload these with your application.

03 Identity and qualification documents

The foundations every application needs.

☐ **Passport or birth certificate** Either is accepted for identity; full, clear colour scan.

☐ **Name-change documents** Only if your name differs across documents.

☐ **Primary physiotherapy degree** Certified copy of your qualifying qualification.

☐ **Academic transcript** Required alongside the degree.

☐ **Curriculum** Required on the General Pathway — often forgotten.

☐ **Clinical hours profile** Required on the General Pathway — often forgotten.

☐ **Certification done correctly** Each document certified, or sent to the Board directly by the issuing authority.

☐ **Translations, if applicable** Certified translation of any non-English document.

04 Registration and good standing

Confirmation you are in good professional standing — mind the three-month rule.

☐ **Evidence of registration — Express and TTMR** Degree or transcript from the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa, or proof of registration with HCPC, CORU, HPCSA, a Canadian regulator or Ahpra.

☐ **Certificates of Good Standing requested** From every physiotherapy regulator you have registered with.

☐ **Good Standing less than three months old at submission** A hard PBNZ rule — do not request them too early.

☐ **Police or criminal history certificates** From every country lived in for twelve months or more in the last ten years since age eighteen.

☐ **Police certificates less than three months old at submission** The same rule — balance it against how long they take to obtain.

05 Experience and English

Proof your skills and communication are current.

☐ **CV on the PBNZ template** The Board's own template, not your format, with every period accounted for.

☐ **Confirm which English route applies** First-language evidence, English-medium education, or a test.

☐ **Sit IELTS Academic, OET, PTE Academic or TOEFL iBT, if required** Meet the minimum in every component, not just overall.

☐ **Check English test validity dates** Results expire, typically after about two years — time it to stay valid through assessment.

06 Competency evidence — Phase 3, General Pathway

Only if your curriculum does not cover every competency.

☐ **Review the assessor's competency request** It lists exactly which competencies still need demonstrating.

☐ **Read the Board's supporting-evidence guidance** Use its guidance document and templates — Reflections, Validation of Work History.

☐ **Gather specific examples for each competency** Detailed evidence from your training or work; already-met ones do not need repeating.

☐ **Submit within three months of the request** Name files clearly; keep folders short and well organised.

07 Submitting your application

Putting it together, cleanly.

- ☐ **Create your application on MyPBNZ** Work through each section carefully and accurately.
- ☐ **Answer the fitness-for-registration questions** English, physical and mental fitness, professional conduct – full, honest disclosure.
- ☐ **Upload documents as clean colour scans** Straight, square, nothing cut off, clearly named.
- ☐ **Pay the applicable fee** Keep your payment confirmation.
- ☐ **Final check, then submit** Could a stranger find everything they need without emailing you?

08 After you submit

Keep things moving to your decision.

- ☐ **Watch for Board communication** Email, including spam, and your MyPBNZ portal – regularly.
- ☐ **Respond to any requests promptly** Speed of response is the biggest factor within your control.
- ☐ **Registration confirmed by the Registrar** General Scope; HPI number issued.
- ☐ **Apply for your Annual Practising Certificate** Via MyPBNZ, before you can practise. The APC year runs to 31 March.

Print or save as PDF

WHAT NEXT?

Registration is one part of the decision

Check my pathway Your profession, where you trained, what you hold – and the route most likely to apply to you. **How registration works in New Zealand** For every profession – the boards, the sequence, English and timelines. **Allied health in New Zealand** The family of professions, and the pages for each. **Physiotherapist** What the work is like, indicative pay, where you could live. **Plan your move** Registration, visas, family and the order to do it in – personalised, saved in your browser.

HOW WE HELP

We can read it before the Board does

We review documents and competency evidence against what the Board looks for and flag likely issues while they are still easy to fix. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand.

Talk to Ethicare

The Board's own site ↗